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Preface to *Tales of Defiance to Mind Control in the Modern Era*

1. Genesis of the Course

I do not think I am going out on a limb by thinking that everyone taking this course has been observing the American and world political scene for decades. A line that comes to mind is, “When I think of the road we’re traveling on, I wonder what’s gone wrong. I can’t help it. I wonder what’s gone wrong.”¹

Granted, not all of you will be obsessed with the dark side. Some know that focusing on the positive is a better way of making a hopeful prophecy self-fulfilling. But for my purposes in trying to control you to be receptive to what I have to say, let us assume that all of you have, at least inchoately, been looking for some time at politics through the lens of mind control.

All of you may have some contradictory senses of what that means, but you might be hoping that I will offer at least a provisional definition of what I mean by it. First, let me distinguish between constructive and destructive mind control, between individual and systemic mind control, and between threatening and enticing mind control.

Constructive vs. Destructive Mind Control

Constructive mind control offers options to improve how we think and feel. Think of an inspiring teacher whose goal is not to bedazzle students, but to get them to think for themselves.

Destructive mind control, on the other hand, manipulates people into thinking within a rigid framework that harms its recipients in the long run. Think about cults², brainwashing prisoners of war³, or dictators who rule by fear or spin⁴. Or think about people who crowd out all reason by mindlessly repeating clichés and slogans, filling our minds and media with bullshit⁵. Speaking of media, the proliferation of media today (social media, blogs, ..., and now AI) exerts tremendous control on the kind of messages we communicate⁶.

¹Quoted lyric from “[American Tune](#)” by Paul Simon.

²See [Steven Hassan’s books on cults](#).

³See [The Instability of Truth](#) by Rebecca Lemov.

⁴See [Spin Dictators](#) by Sergei Guriev & Daniel Treisman.

⁵See [Stupid Idiots](#) by Lars Svendsen and [On Bullshit](#) by Harry G. Frankfurt.

⁶See [The Medium is the Message](#) by Marshall McLuhan.

Individual vs. Systemic Mind Control

Systemic, or system-wide, mind control is what is imposed upon us—either for good or bad—by society. It is structural. It is the water we swim in that we cannot always even see. Think, for example, of [the phrase “under God being inserted into the Pledge of Allegiance in 1954](#) as part of the Cold War against atheist communists.

Individual mind control is what friends, family, acquaintances, our boss, our pastor, our therapist, or our teachers do to try to influence us. At the most personal level, it is what we ourselves do to try to control our own minds. This ranges from impulsively eating chocolate to perk ourselves up, to hours of silent meditation to calm the demons within. In modern parlance, it is the “executive function” decision not to be overwhelmed by anxiety caused by that bad math teacher⁷ and instead to spend a fixed amount of time each day doing our best to learn before taking a break for a healthy diversion⁸.

Since I am all too often a glass-half-empty kind of guy, I have a mathematician’s obsession with looking for patterns, and I have a penchant for theories of everything; the kind of mind control I have worried about for a long time is destructive and systemic. For purposes of our course, it is the default version of mind control that we will mostly focus on here.

In real life, the dichotomies between destructive and constructive, and between individual and systemic, may be useful but are actually quite fuzzy. I hope you will help me break out of my own controlled brain and explore these distinctions rather than use them rigidly.

Threatening vs. Enticing Mind Control

Mind control based on threats, or implicit threats, manipulates people based on when negative emotions like fear and hatred. You could call this mind control of a stick. The systemic and usually destructive version of this often takes the form of a “fear dictator” who rules by threats and punishment. He can also take the form of a more modern “spin dictator”, rules by controlling information flow.

On the other hand, enticing, mind, control controls people, the allure of comfort or riches. The systemic and destructive version of this mind control with a carrot, can take the form of mowing a population into complacency by not only providing for their needs, but by creating a dependency on “false needs”.

More Features of Mind Control Instances

Any particular example of mind control will have one of the possible values of each of the above features, or perhaps have a weighted combination of the different possibilities.

There are many other features that can be used to characterize the nature of instances of mind control. The features are correlated, i.e. having one value of a particular feature says something about the likelihood for the value of another feature.

For example, if a particular case of mind control works by threat, it is more likely to be destructive as well.

There are many other features of the examples of mind control that we consider.

For example, the **extremist vs balanced** feature gauges whether the controller is always pushing a swinging pendulum towards the extreme in one direction vs. nudging towards a balance equilibrium.

Another feature measures whether a mind control instance is intended to make people **stop thought** or if it is meant to **encourage thought**. Stopping thought is likely to be destructive. That is not to say that all forms of encouraging thought are constructive. For example, encouraging bad thought, encouraging people to stew in their own mind, and encouraging dissent can all be destructive.

The **simplicity vs complexity** feature gauges whether a mind control instance pushes toward black-and-white simplicity or whether it encourage people to engage with complexity. Different individuals are more prone to being influenced to think one way or another. Sometimes simplicity is useful to cut through noise,

⁷Apologies to my former students if I have afflicted you this way.

⁸Apologies to myself for the times I have obsessively not followed this strategy.

whereas oversimplification can encourage jumping quickly to the wrong conclusion⁹. The tendency to stop thought is probably highly correlated with the tendency to oversimplify.

2. Shaping the Container

I have spent a long, lonely time¹⁰ striving to understand magic formulas to overcome systemic destructive mind control and “get back to the garden.”¹¹ As you can see from the kind of data analysis approach of the previous section, I am backing down from trying to find solutions to simply trying to find the right questions to ask¹².

To encouraging students to question my biases, I will now admit something. My thinking about mind control has been effected by intense interactions I have had with individuals, and by the particular slice of media I consume. This experience leads me to focus on particular notions about mind control and to worry about how other people’s minds are being over-controlled by certain myths.

A course—not this course—that I have fantasized about putting together would be a kind of philosophical list of do’s and don’t’s for a mature thinker thinking about politics, religion, science, and life, with examples chosen and motivated by my personal experience.

When I started to think of putting together a real course—this course for BOLLI—I realized I needed to get out of my own personal information bubble in order to gain a broader perspective and avoid having the course degenerate into narrow commentary on current politics and personal grievances.

I think abstract themes are only useful if tested against evidence. Unfortunately, a consequence of the polarization our society is currently experiencing is that we cannot even agree on what facts are important, or even what facts are true. So, I decided to step back—or you could call it a retreat—to the world of fiction, where at least we all have equal access to the core facts: those presented in the story being focused on.

To make the course more accessible as a sort of introductory sampler, we will focus on three films and a short story. The heart of this course will be class discussion based on: the sequence of stories we will all be reading or watching, discussion questions about the stories, and short quotes from the stories so that we are starting from the same place.

For each story, I will suggest a tool or “lens” we can use to look at the story. These lenses are just suggestions to foster thinking and discussion; they are not meant to be a barrier of abstractions. The primary goal will be to encounter the stories in their own terms.

I look forward to hearing your arguments, alternatives, and even complaints.

3. What We Will Be Exploring

I call the four stories we will consider, taken together, *an* arc of dystopian stories. Each story represents a kind of dystopia in which systemic forces are used to destructively control the minds of people in society. The protagonists in these stories represent hero figures struggling to see the light. The stories tell tales of attempted defiance.

The stories are dystopian in that each involve a kind of destructive mind control pervasively imposed by the world in which the protagonist lives. I will sometimes refer to the protagonists as “heroes”, in the sense that most readers will be rooting for them in their attempts to resist mind control, not in the sense of foreshadowing that they will succeed.

⁹One of my favorite quote is by Oliver Wendell Holmes, Senior, the father of the supreme court justice: “For the simplicity on this side of complexity, I wouldn’t give you a fig. But for the simplicity on the other side of complexity, for that I would give you anything I have.”

¹⁰“It’s been a long time, been a long lonely, lonely, lonely time,” is a line in “[Rock and Roll \(How the West Was Won\)](#)” by Led Zeppelin.

¹¹“We are stardust, we are golden, and we’ve got to get ourselves back to the garden,” is a line in “[Woodstock](#)” by Joni Mitchell.

¹²It is sometimes said that the hallmark of a great physicist is the ability to hone in on the relevant features (or variables) of a problem. In some sense, physicists face an easier task than what people studying human behaviour face, because result of experiments in physics are fairly repeatable, and often only a small number of variables are necessary to capture the essence of what is going on. This brings up the **holistic vs atomistic** feature.

The kind of mind control the hero is struggling against progresses from story to story, with an evolving, increasingly sophisticated mix of threat and enticement techniques, which are enabled by increasingly powerful, techniques available to the state (or corporations or machines). The techniques of control are cumulative. Just because a new technique evolves, doesn't mean the old ones disappear. In fact, we are struggling today with the techniques in all of the stories in the arc we will consider.

I italicized the first word of “*an* arc of dystopian stories” to make clear that these stories are simply the ones I have selected to demonstrate how the mind control techniques evolve. Sadly, there are many other prophetic choices we could pick. My hope is not that you will think of this arc as some sort of canon, but as an example of how you might get perspective by putting together an arc of stories that speak to you from literature, or your personal life.

As the techniques of dystopian mind control evolve, the tools we use to look at them co-evolve. You could think of them “*an* arc of lenses”, giving a sample of evolving ways to look at stories.

4. The Arc of Stories (and Lenses)

Here is my introduction to the four stories we will look at, and the interpretive arc that I see through dark glasses¹³.

As I describe the stories, I will also introduce some lenses we will use to consider them, and questions that arise from those lenses. I will state the questions in this preface in a generic manner, which can be applied to any of the stories.

I plan to have each of the first four classes mainly focus on one of the stories, with some time in each class connecting to other stories in the arc. When we cover individual stories, I may adapt the questions to the specific circumstances of the story. The fifth and last class will be devoted to overviewing what we have gotten from arc as a whole.

Tale 1: *Notes from Underground*

Lens: Human Outlier Analysis (Foucault – “Madness and Civilization”)

Our first story, *Notes from Underground* by Fyodor Dostoevsky, takes place at a time I am pegging as the start of the “modern age.” The story was first published in Russian in 1864 and takes place in Petersburg around 1862–1864, as the American Civil War is raging and as people in Russia are struggling with whether and how to absorb the lessons of the Western Enlightenment.

The unnamed protagonist of the story, often referred to as Dostoevsky's Underground Man, is in many ways an antihero. What he is defying seems to be the Enlightenment itself, and it's concomitant notions of what is considered sane and acceptable. Many of us today might see the Underground Man as crazy in his verbose rambling and perverse actions. He may seem preposterous and confused, but do we lose something important if he is ostracized as a mental defective?

If we try to understand the Underground Man, perhaps we can better understand our fellow citizens today who seem to want to roll back to a time before Enlightenment values. Perhaps we can learn to recognize that they have important insight, even as we may view them as crazy.

One tool we will introduce could be called human outlier analysis¹⁴.

¹³See:

- King James, 1 Corinthians 13:12: “For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known.”
- [*Through a Glass Darkly*](#), a film by Ingmar Bergman.

¹⁴On human outlier analysis, see:

- *Madness and Civilization* by Michel Foucault, 196.

This posits that a phenomenon of the Age of Reason is the attempt to eliminate the irrational from philosophical discourse. Institutions (such as hospitals and prisons) were developed to outcast radical thinkers as mad or criminal.

We will ask questions about the Underground Man that could well be asked of ourselves and those around us:

- *How is the protagonist unusual in the society they live, and how are they trying to influence society?*
- *Do you sympathize with the protagonist and his plight? What about the other characters?*
- *Can we usefully separate out the dysfunction from the creative insight?*
- *What does the protagonist see about society that those around him do not see?*

Tale 2: 1984

Lenses: The Police State (Foucault – Panopticon), Narrative Analysis (Bruner)

Our next story is *1984* by George Orwell, published in 1949, as society was struggling after WWII with how to face weapons of mass destruction: physical nuclear weapons, global technological warfare, and propaganda used for totalitarian control of minds.

We are all familiar with many references to how aspects of our current society are “Orwellian,” with its police state¹⁵, used to control outliers to the norms of society.

Many of us feel the constant stress of narratives¹⁶ being imposed upon us, often without our conscious knowledge. Like the fish who does not have a concept for water, we may be unaware of how our thoughts are constrained by the hiding of evidence –made concrete in *1984* as the “memory hole” – and by the limitations placed on our very ability to speak –made concrete as Orwell’s language of Newspeak. Orwell’s tale is so powerful because he has constructed a narrative, brilliantly written to focus on possibilities he sees with prophetic vision.

We will ask questions such as:

- *Mental control often attempts to flatten a person’s inner life. How does the narrative use the “intentional states” (private thoughts) of the characters to defy the external world?*
- *In a “mentally controlled world,” the system provides the “canonical script” (how one should think and act). How does the protagonist of our story create a “breach” in that script?*
- *In propaganda-heavy worlds, “truth” is whatever the state says. How does a “tale of defiance” use “narrative truth” to expose the lies of “systemic truth”?*
- *Why do we often use the “Dystopian” genre to talk about mental control? How does the genre itself help us understand what “defiance” looks like?*
- *What helps or hurts the ability of individual acts of defiance “accrue” into a movement?*

Tale 3: The Matrix

Lenses: Societies of Control (Deleuze)

¹⁵On the police state, see:

- [Discipline & Punish \(1975\)](#), [Panopticism](#) by Michel Foucault, Vintage Books, 1995, pp. 195-228 translated from the French by Alan Sheridan, 1977.

Bentham’s Panopticon (late 1700’s) was a prison model where inmates were constantly watched, so that they internalize discipline. In *Discipline and Punish*, Foucault upgrades this model to a metaphor for modern power, with surveillance across schools, factories, hospitals, and society as a whole forces people to regulate themselves.

¹⁶On narrative analysis, see

- [“The Narrative Construction of Reality”](#), Jerome Bruner, Critical Inquiry, Vol. 18, No. 1, Autumn 1991.
- [“Bruner’s Narrative Theory for DMC Course”](#).

In class three, we will focus on the 1999 movie *The Matrix*. The mind control here is total control of reality itself. Our hero, Neo, chooses to swallow the “red pill,” which lets him see that the entire world he has been living in is an elaborate computer simulation.

The previous dystopian elements of controlling outliers via a kind of police state, and controlling the narrative through controlling language are relevant to this story. In addition, the movie is prophetic of the encroachment of virtual reality on our present-day world.

A tool here is to examine how society is being controlled¹⁷.

We will ask questions such as:

- *Who or what is controlling society?*
- *How is it being controlled?*

Tale 4: *The Perfect Match*

Lenses: False Needs (Marcuse), Surveillance Capitalism (Zuboff)

In the short story “The Perfect Match”, the protagonist, Sai, confronts the fact that his desires and preferences are not his own, but being fed to him through chatbots. This presents a modern look at the disappearing line between free will and the “suggestions” of corporate-controlled AI.

One issue this story raises is that of “false needs”¹⁸, that is desires created by capitalist consumer society – such as the urge to buy certain products or relationship – that seem personal but actually keep people dependent, distracted, and less free.

Also relevant is “surveillance capitalism”¹⁹, which is the idea that companies profit by collecting, analyzing, predicting, and influencing people’s behavior, turning personal data into a tool for influence and commercial gain.

- *Can you relate to how the protagonist is controlled through false needs?*
- *Can you relate to how our independence is limited because corporations are always observing us and trying to influence us?*

¹⁷On societies of control, see

- [Postscript on the Societies of Control](#), Gilles Deleuze, *L’Autre journal*, no. 1 (May, 1990).
- [Disciplinary societies and Societies of control](#), CourseCompendium.

“The disciplinary societies, as defined by Foucault, are in the process of becoming societies of control, as defined by Deleuze, Chantal Mouffe (2012: 23) contends. This transition, which does not necessarily imply a complete replacement or displacement, is marked by the emergence of a new paradigm of power. In the disciplinary societies, command is exercised through the articulation of a network of apparatuses (dispositifs) that produce, and regulate customs, habits and practices of production, the major disciplinary institutions being the family, school, factories, asylums and hospitals. In societies of control, however, command is immanent to the social field, distributed to the minds and bodies of the citizens.”

¹⁸On false needs, see:

- *One-Dimensional Man: Studies in the Ideology of Advanced Industrial Society*, Herbert Marcuse, Beacon Press, 1964.
- [Herbert Marcuse’s False Needs Theory – YouTube](#).
- [From 1984 to One-Dimensional Man: Critical Reflections on Orwell and Marcuse](#), Douglas Kellner.

¹⁹On surveillance capitalism, see:

- *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: The Fight for a Human Future at the New Frontier of Power*, Shoshana Zuboff, Profile Books, 2019.
“The titanic power struggles of the twentieth century were between industrial capital and labor, but the twenty-first century finds surveillance capital pitted against the entirety of our societies in a bloodless battle for power and profit as violent as any the world has seen.”
- [The Age of Surveillance Capitalism – Wikipedia](#).
- [Shoshana Zuboff’s The Age of Surveillance Capitalism: A Guide to Fighting Back – YouTube](#).

- *How important is privacy to the main character, and to you?*